

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM - Layered Session Premium Solved-PYQ and Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

BUDDHISM: DEPENDENT PROCESS, NO SUBSTANCE



FOUR SCHOOL ANSWERS TO WHAT IS ULTIMATELY REAL?



Continuity is causal (santana), not substantial; conventional truth preserves ethics and practice.

Concept map for revision; arrows show derivation, not a chronological history of schools.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM - Layered Session Premium

Solved-PYQ and Practice Workbook

Workbook Use Guide

Attempt each verified PYQ before reading its model solution. Then complete the integrated MCQs, remedial MCQs and original Mains practice. Correct MCQ options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: How do the Madhyamika Buddhists apply the notion of Pratityasamutpada to establish their doctrine of Sunyata? Discuss.

Model solution

For Madhyamika, **pratityasamutpada** means that every phenomenon arises only through causes, conditions, conceptual designation, and relations. A thing possessing **svabhava**, or self-existent own-nature, would be independent, unproduced and incapable of alteration. Dependently originated things cannot satisfy that condition.

dependent arising
↓
absence of independent own-nature
↓
emptiness of svabhava
↓
conventional, relational existence

Therefore Nagarjuna treats dependent origination and **sunyata** as two descriptions of the same fact. Emptiness does not mean non-existence. A chariot, person or flame works conventionally, but none exists as a self-grounded substance apart from components and conditions.

The doctrine is protected from nihilism by the **two truths**. At the level of *samvrti-satya*, causation, language, karma and compassion operate. At the level of *paramartha-satya*, no entity survives analysis as intrinsically existent. Sunyata is itself empty and must not be reified into an Absolute.

Verdict: Madhyamika moves from causal dependence to ontological anti-essentialism, not from dependence to sheer nothingness.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact derivation, defines svabhava, uses the two truths, and answers the standard nihilism objection within a compact 10-mark structure.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: Is it consistent for the Buddhists to admit the theory of Nairatmyavada and the doctrine of Nirvana simultaneously? Give reasons in favour of your answer.

Model solution

Nairatmyavada denies a permanent, unchanging owner behind the five skandhas. **Nirvana** is the cessation of ignorance, craving and the causal process that reproduces suffering. The two are consistent if liberation is understood as transformation and cessation within a causal stream, not as the release of an eternal soul.

The person is conventionally designated upon rupa, vedana, samjna, samskara and vijñana. Ignorance imputes an enduring "I" to this changing complex; craving and appropriation follow from that imputation.

self-grasping -> craving -> clinging -> becoming -> suffering
insight into no-self -> non-grasping -> cessation -> nirvana

An opponent may argue that without a self there is nobody who suffers, practises or becomes liberated. Buddhism replies through **santana**, causal continuity. The later liberated stream is neither numerically identical with nor wholly unrelated to the earlier bound stream. Conventional agency remains adequate for discipline and responsibility.

Theravada accounts commonly stress cessation of greed, hatred and delusion; Mahayana adds that samsara and nirvana are not two self-existent realms, because both are empty of svabhava. Neither account requires a substantial

atman.

Verdict: The denial of a permanent self is not an obstacle to nirvana; it is the cognitive condition for ending the grasping that sustains bondage. The residual pressure concerns whether an ownerless stream fully explains first-person liberation.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes self from causal continuity, connects no-self to suffering, adds school nuance, and gives a balanced critical verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: How do the Yogacara Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.

Model solution

Yogacara advances **vijnaptimatratā**: what is given in experience is cognition or representation, not an independently established external object. Dream experience shows that a structured subject-object world can appear without corresponding external things. The object in waking cognition is likewise inseparable from the form in which consciousness presents it.

Yogacara also argues that a material object cannot coherently be identified as one indivisible atom, an aggregate of atoms, or a whole distinct from its parts. Further, a momentary external object would have ceased before the cognition allegedly caused by it became available.

The positive account uses **alaya-vijnana**, the store-consciousness carrying karmic seeds. Seeds mature into coordinated experiences, explaining apparent stability and intersubjective regularity.

Nature	Meaning
Parikalpita	imagined subject-object duality
Paratantra	dependently arisen flow of cognition
Parinippanna	perfected realization of the absence of duality

Verdict: Yogacara denies external objects as independently established causes of experience, but not the ordered causal flow of consciousness. Its weakness is explaining shared experience without covertly rebuilding an external world.

Why this earns marks: It combines the dream and atom arguments with alaya-vijnana and tri-svabhava rather than merely asserting "mind-only."

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question: What is Pratityasamutpada? How do the Buddhists apply this concept to prove that everything is momentary?

Model solution

Pratityasamutpada is the law that conditioned phenomena arise when their conditions arise and cease when those conditions cease. Its existential expression is the twelve-link chain from avidya to jara-marana; its general philosophical form is conditional dependence.

Momentariness follows because a conditioned thing cannot remain unchanged while its conditioning complex changes. Buddhist logicians reinforce this through **arthakriyakaritva**, causal efficacy:

1. The real is what performs a causal function.
2. A wholly permanent thing would possess the same causal capacity at every time.
3. It should therefore produce its effect always or never.
4. If it acts only with auxiliaries, the changed causal situation, not an unchanged substance, explains the effect.
5. Real causal operation belongs to moment-specific events.
6. Hence, *yat sat tat ksanikam* - whatever is real is momentary.

The apparent endurance of a flame, person or seed is explained as **santana**, a succession of causally connected but numerically distinct moments.

Nyaya objects that enduring substances act when helper-conditions arrive and that memory and recognition require identity. Buddhism replies that each causal phase inherits capacities from its predecessor and recognition tracks similarity within a stream. Yet ownership of memory remains a serious pressure point.

Verdict: Dependent origination supplies impermanence; causal efficacy turns it into the stricter doctrine of momentariness.

Why this earns marks: It separates the early causal doctrine from the later logical proof, handles the auxiliary-condition objection, and concludes critically.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: How is Ksanikavada a logical derivative of Pratityasamutpada in Buddhism? Explain.

Model solution

Pratityasamutpada states that no conditioned event is self-grounded: "this being, that arises; with the cessation of this, that ceases." Ksanikavada radicalizes this impermanence into the claim that every causally real entity exists only for a moment.

The derivation has three layers. First, an independently permanent substance would not need conditions. Since phenomena arise and cease with conditions, they lack unchanging substantial existence. Second, a cause that produces an effect has exercised a determinate capacity; the causal phase after production cannot be strictly identical to the phase before it. Third, the arthakriya dilemma states:

If permanent X causes E:
+- simultaneously -> X should produce all effects at once
+- successively -> X has different powers at different times
and is therefore not wholly unchanged

Nyaya invokes **sahakarin**, auxiliary conditions. The Buddhist asks whether X already has the relevant power. If yes, delay is unexplained; if no, the new causal complex bears the explanatory work. Reality thus belongs to momentary causal particulars.

Continuity is preserved as **santana**, a causal succession. This supports memory, karma and rebirth without a permanent bearer, although critics argue that resemblance and causation do not fully explain ownership.

Madhyamika adds that momentary dharmas must not themselves be reified. If they arise dependently, they too are empty of svabhava.

Verdict: Ksanikavada is a logical derivative when pratityasamutpada is joined to causal efficacy. Conditionality establishes impermanence; arthakriya establishes moment-specific reality.

Why this earns marks: It provides a layered derivation, formal dilemma, Nyaya objection and reply, santana, and Madhyamika refinement appropriate to a 20-marker.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2020 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: How does Buddhism explain Self in terms of Pancaskandhas? What is Liberation for Buddhism if there is no Soul?

Model solution

Buddhism analyses the person into five aggregates: **rupa** (form), **vedana** (feeling), **samjna** (recognition), **samskara** (formations), and **vijnana** (consciousness). None is permanent, fully controllable or an adequate self; nor is a self found outside or as owner of them.

The *Milindapanha* chariot analogy clarifies the person's status. "Chariot" designates an organized set of parts; likewise "person" is a conventional designation for an aggregate-stream. This avoids both eternalism and annihilationism: no immutable soul exists, yet a causally continuous process remains.

Liberation is **nirvana**, the cessation of avidya, craving, clinging and production of suffering. The Eightfold Path transforms the stream through morality, concentration and wisdom. The person who begins and the liberated person are causally continuous without being one enduring substance.

An objection says practice is pointless if no one receives its result. The reply is that moral succession requires causal continuity, not numerical identity.

Verdict: Pancaskandha analysis removes the imagined owner; liberation removes the causes of bondage within the conventional continuum.

Why this earns marks: It names all five skandhas, uses the chariot, defines liberation positively, and answers the agency objection.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: Distinguish between pudgala-nairatmyavada and dharma-nairatmyavada with reference to Buddhist Philosophy.

Model solution

Doctrine	What it denies	Primary scope	Typical association
Pudgala-nairatmya	permanent personal self	person composed of five skandhas	shared broadly across Buddhism
Dharma-nairatmya	intrinsic self-nature of dharmas	elements constituting person and world	developed emphatically in Mahayana

Pudgala-nairatmya says no owner exists apart from the aggregates. The person is a conventional designation upon a causal stream. Some Abhidharma realists nevertheless treat the constituent dharmas as ultimately real.

Dharma-nairatmya extends the critique: even dharmas do not possess independent svabhava. Madhyamika grounds this in dependent origination; Yogacara connects it with absence of subject-object duality.

The second doctrine prevents analysis of the person from turning dharmas into metaphysical atoms. Together they remove selfhood at personal and elemental levels.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact object of denial, identifies the school-level development, and explains why the second doctrine is necessary.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2021 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Momentariness denies an enduring mental subject, apparently making memory impossible: the experiencer has perished before remembering occurs. Buddhism responds with **santana**, a causal continuum. An experience leaves a disposition in the next moment; transmission produces a later memory.

Sautrantika speaks of causal seeds or traces. Yogacara uses **alaya-vijnana**, whose bija preserve karmic and mnemonic potential. Personal identity is conventional continuity based on causal connection, bodily organization, resemblance and inherited dispositions:

experience -> impression -> transmitted seed -> occasioning condition -> memory

The later rememberer is neither strictly the same as nor wholly other than the earlier experiencer. Strict identity would reintroduce an atman; total difference would destroy responsibility.

Nyaya objects that memory has the form "I experienced this," requiring one subject to connect the cognitions. Similarity may explain resemblance but not ownership. Buddhism replies that ownership is itself constructed within a causally integrated stream.

Verdict: Buddhist models explain informational transmission economically, but remain vulnerable if first-person appropriation is treated as irreducible.

Why this earns marks: It addresses both memory and identity, names school-specific mechanisms, and gives the strongest Nyaya objection and reply.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma? How do Buddhists respond to objections raised by opponents? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Karma appears to require a persisting agent who acts and later receives the fruit. Ksanikavada denies such an enduring subject. Buddhism reconciles them by replacing substance-identity with causal continuity.

intention -> karmic impression -> causal transmission -> maturation -> fruit

Sautrantika uses seed-like causal potency; Yogacara locates bija in alaya-vijnana; Abhidharma traditions employ causal relations within the dharma-series. All reject an unchanging owner.

Nyaya and Mimamsa raise three objections:

1. **Krtanasa:** the doer's destruction seems to make the deed lost.
2. **Akrtabhyagama:** a later different moment seems to receive an unperformed act's fruit.
3. Praise, blame and recognition seem to require one subject.

Buddhism replies that these objections assume only absolute identity or absolute difference. A causally continuous stream is sufficiently connected for responsibility. A child and adult differ profoundly, yet ordinary morality treats them as one practical continuum.

The pressure remains: causal inheritance explains why B follows A, but does it explain why the fruit is *mine*? Alaya-vijnana improves continuity but may resemble a quasi-self. Madhyamika avoids reifying even the stream and treats karma as conventionally valid.

Verdict: Karma and momentariness are compatible if moral responsibility needs causal and conventional identity rather than a numerically identical substance.

Why this earns marks: It states the compatibility mechanism, names classical objections, differentiates schools, and reaches a genuinely critical verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2022 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with No-soul.

Model solution

The **Triratna** are Buddha, Dhamma and Sangha. Buddha is the awakened teacher and exemplar; Dhamma is truth and path; Sangha is the community preserving and embodying the path.

Buddha discovers and teaches Dhamma
Dhamma makes awakening intelligible
Sangha preserves and practises Dhamma
Sangha produces further exemplars

No-soul does not contradict refuge in Buddha because Buddha is not an eternal atman or creator. Nor does it contradict Sangha, a conventional community of causal persons. Dhamma explicitly includes insight into anatta.

The objection is that refuge and discipline require stable agents and authorities. Buddhism answers through two levels: conventionally, teachers and practitioners exist; ultimately, none possesses independent selfhood.

Verdict: Triratna and no-self are consistent when refuge is practical orientation rather than submission of one immortal soul to another.

Why this earns marks: It defines each jewel, shows their internal relation, and resolves the issue through conventional and ultimate levels.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2023 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: "Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present Buddhist soteriology in this light.

Model solution

Buddhist soteriology treats suffering as a dependently sustained process. **Avidya** misconstrues impermanent, conditioned and selfless phenomena as permanent, satisfactory and owned by a self. This error generates craving and clinging.

avidya -> samskara -> vijñāna -> nama-rupa -> saṁskāra
-> sparsa -> vedāna -> trsna -> upādāna -> bhava -> jati
-> jara-marana

Knowledge reverses the chain's practical force. Feeling need not become craving; craving need not become clinging. Insight into impermanence and no-self removes appropriation, while sila and samadhi weaken habits reproducing ignorance.

Division	Path factors	Function
Prajna	right view, right resolve	sees dependence and no-self
Sila	speech, action, livelihood	stops fresh harmful conditioning
Samadhi	effort, mindfulness, concentration	transforms attention and craving

Abhidharma analyses the causal stream into dharmas. Yogacara purifies seeds in consciousness. Madhyamika sees dependent phenomena as empty, preventing attachment even to doctrine and nirvana.

Mere verbal knowledge cannot liberate; wisdom must become non-grasping perception supported by conduct and meditation.

Verdict: Ignorance is suffering because it constructs appropriation in the causal chain. Knowledge is cessation when embodied as a path that removes renewed craving's conditions.

Why this earns marks: It integrates the quotation, twelve links, Eightfold Path, school nuance, and the distinction between intellectual and transformative knowledge.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2024 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: How do two schools arrive at "everything is void" and "everything is real" from the same doctrine of Pratityasamutpada?

Model solution

The opposition arises because schools ask different questions of dependent origination.

Madhyamika: If a thing arises dependently, it lacks svabhava. What lacks self-nature is **sunya**. "Everything is void" means no dharma is intrinsically existent; conventional causation remains valid.

Vaibhasika and Sautrantika: Causal interaction shows conditioned dharmas are real. Vaibhasika holds external dharmas directly perceived; Sautrantika infers external momentary particulars from representations. "Everything is real" means causally efficacious dharmas are not illusions, though impermanent.

Shared premise	Realist inference	Madhyamika inference
things arise through conditions	causal efficacy establishes conditioned reality	dependence disproves intrinsic nature
no permanent substance	momentary dharmas are real	even momentary dharmas are empty
ordinary practice works	realism explains causal order	convention explains causal order

The conclusions conflict only if "real" and "void" are univocal. Realists affirm causal reality; Madhyamika denies ultimate self-existence.

Verdict: One doctrine supports realism about causal functioning and emptiness about self-nature. The real dispute is whether momentary dharmas remain ultimately real.

Why this earns marks: It identifies the schools, distinguishes two senses of reality, and dissolves superficial contradiction without erasing genuine disagreement.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2025 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: Is Buddhist Nirvana in consonance with Ksanikavada and Nairatmyavada? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Nirvana is consonant with momentariness and no-self if understood as cessation of suffering's causes, not an eternal soul entering a permanent state. Ksanikavada shows conditioned processes can cease; nairatmyavada shows liberation needs no immutable owner.

conditioned arising of suffering
↓ insight and path
cessation of its causes
↓
nirvana

An opponent argues that if nirvana is real and permanent, it contradicts momentariness; if momentary, it cannot be final; and without a self, nobody attains it. Buddhism replies that ksanikavada applies to conditioned entities. Nirvana is **asamskrta**, unconditioned, or more cautiously the cessation of the conditioned process. No subject-substance is required for cessation.

Madhyamika refuses to reify nirvana. Samsara and nirvana are empty of svabhava; their distinction concerns ignorance and insight, not two substances.

Verdict: The doctrines are consonant within process ontology. Tension appears only if nirvana is interpreted as an eternal positive entity or personal attainment is assumed to require a substantial self.

Why this earns marks: It answers both compatibility conditions, distinguishes conditioned from unconditioned, adds Madhyamika nuance, and identifies the exact source of possible inconsistency.

Integrated MCQ Loop - 24 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
1	The general formula of pratityasamutpada states that: A. conditioned events arise and cease with conditions B. every effect pre-exists materially in its cause C. an eternal self coordinates change D. God initiates the causal series	A	Dependent origination is conditional arising and cessation.
2	In the twelve-link chain, craving is followed by: A. feeling B. clinging C. contact D. consciousness	B	Trsna conditions upadana.
3	The Buddhist middle way avoids: A. realism and idealism B. perception and inference C. eternalism and annihilationism D. ethics and meditation	C	Dependent process is neither immutable substance nor sheer nullity.
4	Arthakriyakaritva means: A. universal predicability B. linguistic definition C. permanent identity D. capacity for causal efficacy	D	Buddhist logicians connect reality with effect-producing capacity.
5	The simultaneity horn says a permanent cause would: A. produce all effects at once B. possess no quality C. become universal D. require perception only	A	Complete unchanged power gives no reason for delayed production.
6	Santana means: A. permanent substance B. causal continuum C. creator consciousness D. universal inherence	B	It explains continuity without numerical identity.
7	The chariot analogy establishes: A. direct realism B. atomism C. conventional personhood without substantial self D. divine causation	C	Person is designated upon organized aggregates.
8	Which is not a skandha? A. rupa B. vedana C. vijnana D. atman	D	Atman is what aggregate analysis does not find.
9	Pudgala-nairatmya denies: A. enduring personal self B. conventional persons C. causal relations D. liberation	A	It denies substance-self, not conventional designation.
10	Dharma-nairatmya is strongest in: A. materialism B. Mahayana C. Nyaya D. Mimamsa	B	Mahayana extends no-self to dharmas.
11	Vaibhasika is: A. absolute idealism B. nihilism C. direct realism D. Advaita	C	External dharmas are directly perceived.
12	Sautrantika knows external objects through: A. revelation B. yogic intuition C. non-cognition D. inference from representations	D	It is inferential or representational realism.
13	Yogacara's store-consciousness is: A. alaya-vijnana B. mano-vijnana C. kevala-jnana D. saksi	A	It carries seeds and dispositions.
14	Imagined subject-object duality is: A. paratantra B. parikalpita C. parinispanna D. paramartha	B	Parikalpita is constructed nature.
15	Sunyata means: A. absolute non-being B. hidden substance C. absence of intrinsic nature D. denial of conventional causation	C	Emptiness is anti-essentialism.
16	The two truths are: A. perception and inference B. being and non-being C. self and matter D. conventional and ultimate	D	Samvrti and paramartha prevent nihilism and reification.
17	Catuskoti examines: A. is, is not, both, neither B. one, many, universal, particular C. cause, effect, substance, quality D. four pramanas	A	The tetralemma tests reified alternatives.
18	Emptiness of emptiness prevents: A. causation B. reification of sunyata C. conduct D. speech	B	Sunyata is not a new Absolute.
19	Dignaga-Dharmakirti admit: A. one pramana B. three C. two D. six	C	Perception and inference are fundamental.

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
20	Svalaksana is: A. universal B. self C. verbal construction D. unique causal particular	D	It is the ultimate object of non-conceptual perception.
21	Apoha explains meaning by: A. exclusion of the other B. eternal universals C. divine convention D. substance-contact	A	"Cow" works by excluding non-cows.
22	Memory is explained through: A. eternal witness B. causal transmission in a stream C. denial of memory D. body alone	B	Santana, seeds and alaya transmit dispositions.
23	Karma avoids strict identity and difference through: A. inference B. creator C. causal continuity D. permanent moral self	C	The recipient belongs to the same stream.
24	Nirvana with no-self is: A. ego immortality B. atman migration C. permanent-person destruction D. cessation without eternal owner	D	Liberation is cessation within process ontology.

Remedial MCQ Loop - 8 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
25	Correct sequence: A. vedana -> trsna -> upadana -> bhava B. trsna -> vedana -> bhava -> sparsa C. upadana -> sparsa -> vedana -> avidya D. bhava -> avidya -> vijnana -> vedana	A	Feeling conditions craving, clinging and becoming.
26	Dependent origination is not fatalism because: A. events are uncaused B. changing conditions can interrupt suffering C. God controls karma D. self escapes causation	B	Practice can alter conditioned causes.
27	Madhyamika differs from Vaibhasika because: A. only Madhyamika accepts causation B. only Vaibhasika denies self C. Madhyamika empties dharmas while Vaibhasika treats them as ultimately real D. Vaibhasika denies objects	C	Their dispute concerns dharmas' ultimate status.
28	Safest Yogacara interpretation: A. nothing exists B. it equals Advaita C. it proves creator mind D. it critiques independent objecthood while preserving cognitive order	D	This avoids crude nihilism and false equation.
29	Nyaya recognition objection says: A. "this is that" requires enduring identity B. perception is false C. universals are momentary D. memory proves emptiness	A	Pratyabhijna pressures stream theories.
30	Buddhist reply on auxiliaries: A. auxiliaries are unreal B. changed causal complex does the work if cause is unchanged C. permanent things cannot coexist D. all effects are simultaneous	B	It challenges an unchanged cause's contribution.
31	No-self is not annihilationism because: A. subtle ego remains B. persons never die C. causal and conventional continuity remains D. nirvana is material survival	C	Substance-self is denied, not process.
32	Best verdict: A. schools share nothing B. sunyata is nothingness C. ethics is impossible D. Buddhism replaces substance-identity with causal continuity, though ownership objections remain	D	It captures the strength and residual pressure.

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain why pratityasamutpada is simultaneously a theory of causation and a method of liberation.

Model solution

Pratityasamutpada explains causation by showing that conditioned phenomena arise and cease with supporting conditions. It is soteriological because suffering is one such conditioned process. Avidya generates formations, craving and clinging; removing these conditions prevents renewed becoming.

Its practical significance is that the chain is interruptible, especially at the movement from feeling to craving. Wisdom sees impermanence and no-self; morality and meditation alter the affective conditions of the stream.

Verdict: It is not a neutral cosmology later applied to salvation. Its causal grammar reveals both why suffering arises and how it can cease.

Why this earns marks: It states both dimensions, identifies an intervention point, and concludes with their internal unity.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 15 marks

Question: Compare Vaibhasika, Sautrantika, Yogacara and Madhyamika as answers to the problem of the object of knowledge.

Model solution

School	Object position	Knowledge relation	Main pressure
Vaibhasika	external dharma are real	directly perceived	direct access to momentary objects
Sautrantika	external objects are real	inferred from mental forms	copy cannot prove unknown original
Yogacara	independent external object denied	cognition presents subject and object	shared experience
Madhyamika	mind and object lack svabhava	claims operate conventionally	self-refutation charge

The movement is not a ladder in which one school simply wins. Vaibhasika protects causal realism; Sautrantika recognizes mediation; Yogacara exposes experience's mind-structured character; Madhyamika criticizes reification of both object and consciousness.

Verdict: The debate shifts from *which object is known* to *whether knower or known possesses intrinsic nature*. Madhyamika is most radical but depends on conventional truth to preserve inquiry.

Why this earns marks: It compares all four on one axis, gives each strength and objection, and avoids presenting the sequence as mere chronology.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 20 marks

Question: "Buddhist process ontology secures change more successfully than it secures responsibility." Critically examine.

Model solution

Buddhist process ontology explains change powerfully. Pratityasamutpada replaces static substance with conditional arising; ksanikavada explains causal novelty through moment-specific efficacy; nairatmyavada removes an unchanging owner incompatible with experiential flux.

Responsibility is harder. Karma requires that an intentional act and its later fruit belong together. Buddhism answers through santana, transmitted dispositions, pratisandhana and, in Yogacara, alaya-vijnana with karmic seeds. The later recipient is neither identical with nor unrelated to the agent.

This blocks the crude charges of lost action and undeserved result. Ordinary responsibility already tracks psychological and causal continuity despite bodily and mental change. Madhyamika argues that agency operates

conventionally and never required ultimate substance.

Yet causal connection explains why event B follows A more readily than why B's suffering is *my* fruit. Nyaya treats memory and appropriation as evidence of an enduring subject. Alaya-vijnana improves continuity but risks resembling a disguised self.

The Buddhist reply is that "mine" is itself constructed within an integrated stream. Responsibility is preserved by appropriate causal inheritance, not metaphysical ownership.

Verdict: Buddhism explains change better than substance theories that leave alteration mysterious. Its account of responsibility is coherent but less decisive because the move from causal continuity to ownership remains contestable.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates both halves, names multiple continuity devices, includes Nyaya's strongest challenge, and reaches a qualified verdict.
